

**LCoS****What is it?**

Liquid Crystal on Silicon is a display technology that rivals our more traditional LCD and TFT in TVs and monitors, and DLP in projectors.

When did this happen?

The technology has been around for nearly a decade, but has only now started to come out of its niche and into consumer markets.

What's the big deal?

While other technologies have started out awful and have gotten better over the years, LCoS comes into the game at the top of its competitors—its quality surpasses LCD and DLP by a large margin.

How does it work?

LCoS works much like DLP, only using Liquid Crystal instead of the little mirrors that DLP uses to build the image. This makes it capable of much larger resolutions than LCD and Plasma.

Who's been promoting it?

JVC has been manufacturing high-resolution projectors since 1998, and big players such as Sony, Hitachi, and Toshiba have started to join the club with their own HD TVs and projectors. We're actually waiting for Hitachi to announce their much-awaited but indefinitely postponed 70-inch LCoS HDTVs.

Why am I only just hearing about this?

While LCoS actually works out to be more economical when manufacturing TVs, there's a catch. It's an expensive technology to get right, and a lot of money has already been sunk for it. Still, we should see some more commercial products soon.

CO-EXISTENCE—LITERALLY

One Disc For All: End Of The Format Wars?

Recall the HD-DVD and Blu-ray format war, about which we spoke in our December 2005 issue (*The Battle Of The Blue*). We mentioned that one possibility was that the formats could co-exist. However, we didn't mean "co-exist" in a sense this literal: a patent application has been filed for a disc that can record and play both formats!

The "multilayer dual optical disk" would have one layer of data in the standard CD or DVD format, a second layer to play HD-DVD, and a third layer for Blu-ray.

If the format is successful, it could mean a major twist in the tale for the format war.

The application was filed by three employees of Warner Bros., two of whom are engineers with the company.

To recapitulate, the confusion will force consumers to pick one format or the other—a situation that analysts predict will stifle growth for the next generation of optical discs.

Hollywood studios have been taking sides, with each major one supporting one or the other.

"From the standpoint of a manufacturer, it is disadvantageous to have to manufacture and distribute three different types of disc formats to satisfy consumer demand for one product—such as a motion picture," the inventors of the new disc—Wayne Smith, Alan Bell and Lewis Ostrover—said in their patent application.

ME TOO—AGAIN

Microsoft's Expected Answer To YouTube

As direct competition to YouTube, and also the 200 start-ups that intend to enter the online video fray, Microsoft has launched a beta version of Soapbox (<http://soapbox.msn.com>), their new video-sharing service. It has the key advantage of being tightly integrated into Microsoft's other online services.

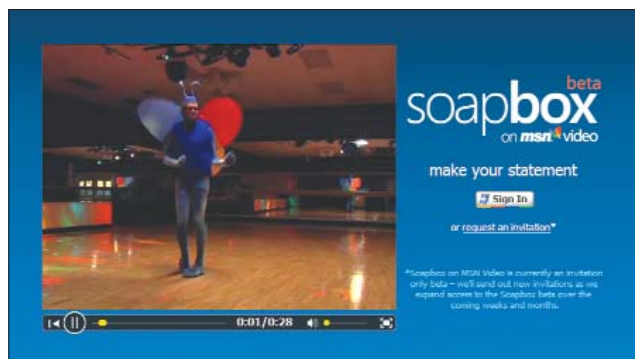
Functionality-wise, Soapbox will enable users to upload videos in several formats, assign categories to them, and share them with other people. There are 15 categories to browse through; one can find related videos and subscribe to RSS feeds as well. Technicians who worked on Soapbox claim it will be more bandwidth-efficient than the competition.

integrated throughout Microsoft's portfolio of online services, including Windows Live Spaces and Windows Live Messenger." Soapbox probably does have a huge advantage as a direct result of this—the standalone YouTube could have hard work ahead of it. Microsoft could also link Soapbox with Zune, Microsoft's new media player, using which users can share content wirelessly.

In an effort to catch up on the social networking front, there is also the "Soapbox community", a set of tools that allow users to discuss videos. This service will be closely linked with Microsoft's Live Spaces blogging site.

The beta of Soapbox on MSN Video is being made available in the US, but on an invitation-only basis. No date had been given for a commercial launch at the time of writing.

It was only a matter of time before Microsoft entered the arena. There's nothing earth-shattering about Soapbox, of course. People who currently use YouTube (and the rest of the slew of similar



MSN Video, Microsoft's current online video service, is already viewed by more than 11 million unique users per month. YouTube, in comparison, has 20 million unique users per month, according to Nielsen NetRatings. The point here is, however, more than 465 million people per month log on to MSN worldwide!

Microsoft promises that Soapbox "will be deeply

services) really have no compelling reason to switch to Soapbox. Could this be another case of Microsoft's ego getting in the way of their focus?

In any case, it won't take long for us to see whether the integration with such services as Live Spaces and Live Messenger does bestow an advantage on the software giant in a space they aren't half experts in. ■